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Gender, reason and agriculture

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Performing Power: Sexuality, Work and the Healing Household

One local healer, whose extramarital affairs were not a secret in Nyandira, tried at first to convince me that this was not a problem for healing, saying that the most important taboo is against having sexual relations with someone that you are presently treating. However, after further discussion he admitted that this was wrong, and that, indeed, it is much preferred if you do not have sexual relations outside of marriage.

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In a related vein, sexuality is currently linked to power, fertility and abundance in Mgeta in another sense. One hears many jokes made by women regarding the "food rations" (*posho*) that women distribute to their husbands. As described previously, Pels (1999) has described the "commodification" of women's bodies accompanying wage labor and women's need to secure their access to men's labor and incomes. Yet, there is alternative aspect of this discourse that is relevant to the current discussion. *Posho* represents the amount of food which is necessary to survival and livelihood. Men who earn money to feed their family are said to bring *posho* home to their wife and children. People [281](#) who work to earn their daily bread are said to be providing themselves with *posho*. One therefore finds that "food" is used in

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this context interchangeably with *posho*. For example, the term *ugali* (maize porridge) is often substituted for *posho* in the image of women's sexuality, *ugali* being the staple of the local diet.¹¹ Therefore, I would argue that, beyond the exchange of sex for labor, lies an important relationship between the meanings of sex, food, and marriage. Wives and husbands view themselves as mutually engaged in a number of activities for the production of livelihood.

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¹¹ Mama Mwenda told a funny story about how her mother-in-law once asked her if she was going home to give "food" to Baba Mwenda. When she asked, "What food?" her mother-in-law stated, "the food that you close in a satchel and walk around with everyday"

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